

Suspect went from evangelist to zealot

Residents in Minn. town struggle to make sense of attacks on lawmakers

BY DUSTIN NELSON, ANNIE GOWEN, JONATHAN O'CONNELL AND MICHELLE BOORSTEIN

SLEEPY EYE, MINN. — Vance Boelter grew up in a sports-loving Lutheran family in a small Minnesota town where nobody locked their doors — a background that gave little hint of the zealotry to come or the deadly violence of which he is now accused.

At 17, he had a religious conversion. As he recalled decades later during a passionate sermon overseas, what happened next shook his life. Waving a Bible and thundering from the podium, he spoke about meeting the Holy Spirit and running off pamphlets about Jesus to give to everyone he knew.

“So often in the world today, everyone wants an excuse for not doing the right thing. We want to blame someone else,” he preached in the Democratic Republic of Congo, as seen in a video posted online. “God doesn’t say, ‘Oh, your parents messed up, I know you came into this world all troubled.’ ... You have a choice, you have a decision.”

Friends and neighbors of the 57-year-old say they are struggling to understand what drove him to allegedly masquerade as a police officer and shoot two state legislators and their spouses in the predawn hours of Saturday — leaving state Rep. Melissa Hortman and her husband dead and the other couple seriously injured. Some point to his teenage conversion and the startling change that followed, one that became very public in Sleepy Eye, a burg of about 3,500 about two hours southwest of Minneapolis.

Through much of high school, Boelter was like every other teen, according to lifelong friend David Carlson. But after Boelter declared himself a born-again Christian, he began preaching in the local park — even living there in a tent, Carlson said.

“Everything in his life — he just changed,” Carlson said Sunday. SEE BOELTER ON A4

Trump weighs joining assault on Iran



ATTA KENARE/AFP/GETTY IMAGES

People in Tehran stand on a smoking rooftop Tuesday after an overnight Israeli strike. Iran's retaliatory barrages carried on for a fifth day.

As Iranian missiles hit, Israelis say they are losing long-held sense of security

BY SHIRA RUBIN

TEL AVIV — For five days, Iran's ballistic missile salvos against Israel have torn through residential buildings and killed two dozen civilians, set cars and infrastructure ablaze, and have Israelis questioning their already fractured sense of security.

In Tel Aviv, Israel's otherwise bustling financial and cultural hub, the streets have gone quiet as schools and nonessential businesses have closed, public transportation has been scaled back and the military has banned public gatherings. Israel has fired missiles primarily at Tel Aviv and its surroundings, as well as at Haifa, a key port city in the north, after Israel began attacking Iranian military and nuclear sites Friday.

Some residents of Israel's commercial capital, which has a population of about 500,000, have left their homes to stay with family outside the city. Others

have stayed, fleeing to shelters at night, which is when most of the missiles rain down.

“The fact that you don’t know if the missiles are about to fall on you, that we are now living with this feeling of helplessness, it’s insane,” said Ella Keren, a nurse who was with her two young daughters at a Tel Aviv playground Tuesday.

Keren and her family are among the many in Israel trying to fill the unstructured days after sleepless nights. She said she does not see herself as an “anxious person,” but since the conflict with Iran started, Keren vacillates between “extreme fear, that if something happens — if I die — I will be separated from my girls,” on the one hand, and “radical acceptance, that this is just it,” on the other.

For the past 20 months, since Hamas attacked Israel on Oct. 7, 2023, Israelis have grown used to SEE ISRAEL ON A10



MAHMOUD ILLEAN/AP

Mourners in Tamra, Israel, attend a funeral Tuesday for four Palestinian citizens of Israel killed in an Iranian missile strike.

Israeli strikes: A young poet was among the first Iranians killed. A11

Munitions: Stocks of missiles, interceptors may dictate length of fight. A11

Many wanted immigration enforcement. But not this.

In a closely divided area north of L.A., voters draw the line at some of the tactics in Trump’s crackdown

BY MAEVE RESTON

PALMDALE, CALIF. — Jesus Martinez, a 36-year-old aerospace worker, said he initially supported President Donald Trump's decision to send the military to quell immigration protests in California. But he has grown increasingly uneasy after seeing images of ICE raids near schools and at workplaces where families are being separated.

“It’s going overboard. It’s too much,” said Martinez, a former Democrat who supported Trump in 2020 and sat out the 2024 election.

“They said only criminals, and now they’re saying, ‘Well, they did come in illegally, so they are criminals,’” he added. “Hispanics or Latinos that voted for Trump, they didn’t think he was going to go after kids.”

Trump’s promises to crack down on illegal immigration helped him win back the White House in 2024 and increase his voting share among young voters, working-class people and



SALWAN GEORGES/THE WASHINGTON POST

Marines stand guard outside a federal building in Los Angeles on Friday, part of an effort to contain protests.

Latinos. But interviews with more than four dozen people in the Antelope Valley, a closely divided region of the state about an hour north of Los Angeles, show that tactics very much mat-

ter.

In this working-class and heavily Latino area known for its wildflower blooms, a region that moved toward Trump in the 2024 election, voters from both parties

voiced support for Trump's promises to deport immigrants who are here illegally, especially those with criminal records. But they drew lines — some over the scope of those deportations and, to a lesser extent, over his decision to crack down on immigration protesters with the military.

“When you already have aggressive people and then you’re sending in people like that, I feel like it just makes it kind of worse,” said Christian Strand, a 19-year-old EMT from Palmdale, a majority-Latino city, referring to the deployment of National Guard troops and Marines. “It’s creating more of a pushback, because the aggression is rising.”

“It’s a little unclear what’s happening. If you’re targeting gangs, or drugs, things like that — yeah — but if you’re targeting single homes and families, it’s a tough call,” said Joseph Kennedy, a 62-year-old retired engineer SEE IMMIGRATION ON A6

N.Y. arrest: A mayoral candidate was detained by ICE agents. A7

Hemp drink craze draws businesses — and critics

Many want industry to face the same regulations as alcohol and cannabis

BY SHANNON NAJMABADI

States are rushing to ban or restrict sales of intoxicating cannabis drinks that have exploded in popularity in a market lacking many of the regulations imposed on marijuana.

The drinks get their psychoactive properties from hemp, marijuana's less potent and less regulated cousin. They can be sold outside dispensaries — in some states, to minors — and are increasingly drawing a variety of consumers including sober-curious drinkers and craft beer enthusiasts, industry experts say.

The boom has sparked a wave of lawsuits and legislation, as officials try to rein in a rapidly

growing industry that is drawing interest from business groups such as brewers or alcohol distributors who want a piece of the nascent market.

More than 80 bills regulating hemp beverages were introduced in state legislatures this year, according to government relations firm MultiState. Lawmakers in Alabama, Georgia and Texas — one of the country's largest hemp markets — have recently tried to ban intoxicating hemp drinks. Congress is considering a similar measure.

“We’ve got to get the genie back in the bottle,” said Texas state Sen. Charles Perry (R) at a hearing in March.

Cannabis can be classified as hemp if its concentration of THC — the psychoactive compound that helps produce feelings of relaxation and euphoria — remains at 0.3 percent or less by dry weight. Anything with a higher THC concentration is considered marijuana. SEE CANNABIS ON A14

IN THE NEWS

**Views of GOP bill** The Republican tax-and-spending legislation faces opposition by a roughly 2-to-1 margin, according to a new Washington Post-Ipsos poll. A3

**Virginia elections** Democratic primary voters chose nominees to run with gubernatorial nominee Abigail Spanberger in fall races. B1

**THE NATION** Justice Ketanji Brown Jackson disclosed a \$2 million advance payment for her memoir. A2

**Eight senators** urged Democratic leaders to make a sharp break with billionaire donors. A5

**THE WORLD** At least 15 people, including a U.S. citizen, were killed in a Russian attack in Kyiv. A8

**British lawmakers** voted to decriminalize abortions after 24 weeks in England and Wales. A9

**THE ECONOMY** As the GOP looks to cut the Affordable Care Act, a conservative group said millions are improperly receiving federal subsidies. A13

**Kraft Heinz** will purge certain artificial dyes from its products, such as Kool-Aid and Jell-O, by the end of 2027. A14

**THE REGION** Mayor Muriel E. Bowser is pushing the D.C. Council to pass stricter curfew laws for teens and young people. B1

**Tara H. Jackson (D)**, the acting Prince George's County executive, was appointed the interim state's attorney. B1

**STYLE** Headed to the office? Our guide on how to dress appropriately has you covered. C1

**FOOD** The traditional Roman recipe for cacio pepe is notoriously tricky to prepare. A little butter makes it much more forgiving. E1

|                    |     |
|--------------------|-----|
| BUSINESS NEWS..... | A13 |
| COMICS.....        | C5  |
| OBITUARIES.....    | B4  |
| OPINION PAGES..... | A15 |
| TELEVISION.....    | C4  |
| WORLD NEWS.....    | A8  |

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